clearance and she offered to practice with me—a goofy kind of foreplay. The philosophy she lived by was the perfect training: say what you want, say who you are, never be ashamed. If they reject you, it's their problem. I'd never been so comfortable around someone, and I'd never been so willing to be called out for my faults. I even let her take my photo.

I had her voice in my head on my drive to the NSA's oddly named Friendship Annex complex for the final interview for my security clearance. I found myself in a windowless room, bound like a hostage to a cheap office chair. Around my chest and stomach were pneumographic tubes that measured my breathing. Finger cuffs on my fingertips measured my electrodermal activity, a blood pressure cuff around my arm measured my heart rate, and a sensor pad on the chair detected my every fidget and shift. All of these devices—wrapped, clamped, cuffed, and belted tightly around me—were connected to the large black polygraph machine placed on the table in front of me.

Behind the table, in a nicer chair, sat the polygrapher. She reminded me of a teacher I once had—and I spent much of the test trying to remember the teacher's name, or trying not to. She, the polygrapher, began asking questions. The first ones were no-brainers: Was my name Edward Snowden? Was 6/21/83 my date of birth? Then: Had I ever committed a serious crime? Had I ever had a problem with gambling? Had I ever had a problem with alcohol or taken illegal drugs? Had I ever been an agent of a foreign power? Had I ever advocated the violent overthrow of the United States government? The only admissible answers were binary: "Yes" and "No." I answered "No" a lot, and kept waiting for the questions I'd been dreading. "Have you ever impugned the competence and character of the medical staff at Fort Benning online?" "What were you searching for on the network of the Los Alamos Nuclear Laboratory?" But those questions never came and, before I knew it, the test was over.

I'd passed with flying colors.

As required, I had to answer the series of questions three times in total, and all three times I passed, which meant that not only had I qualified for the TS/SCI, I'd also cleared the "full scope polygraph"—the highest clearance in the land.

I had a girlfriend I loved and I was on top of the world.

I was twenty-two years old.